Who Gets a Good Pass? Mapping Disadvantaged Pupils' GCSE Outcomes in English Secondary Schools

A briefing for the National Institute of Teaching

April 2026

The Gap That Isn't Closing

Every year, fewer than **three in ten** disadvantaged pupils in England achieve a "good pass" — grade 5 or above in both GCSE English Language and Mathematics. Among their better-off classmates, it is more than **five in ten**.

That gap — around 27 percentage points — is wider today than it was before the pandemic. Despite billions of pounds in Pupil Premium funding, despite decades of school improvement effort, and despite a stated government commitment to halve it, the gap has barely moved.

This briefing uses the most recent published data (2024–25) to ask a more focused question: **are there schools that are beating the odds?** And if so, what can we learn from them?

The National Picture

What we mean by a "good pass": GCSE grade 5 or above in *both* English Language and Mathematics. This is the government's "strong pass" measure — one step above the grade 4 standard pass. It is widely used as a threshold for progression to A-level and higher education.

What we mean by "disadvantaged": Pupils who have been eligible for free school meals at any point in the past six years, or who are looked after. This is the definition used for Pupil Premium funding — it is broader than current free school meal eligibility, and better reflects persistent disadvantage.

Most recent national results (2023–24)

The most recent published national breakdown by disadvantage status is from 2023–24. (2024–25 provisional results have been published at school level — which forms the basis of the school analysis later in this briefing — but the national headline percentages by disadvantage group had not been published at the time this briefing was prepared.)

Group	Good pass rate (2023–24)
Disadvantaged pupils	**26%**
Non-disadvantaged pupils	**53%**
Gap	**27 percentage points**

The Schools White Paper (February 2026) sets a national ambition to **halve this gap** — from around 27pp to approximately 13–14pp. On current trends, that would require disadvantaged pupils' pass rate to rise from 26% to around 40%, or a combination of improvement at the bottom and narrowing from the top.

How has it changed?

The gap has **widened since 2019**, not narrowed. The 2018–19 figure was 25pp; the 2023–24 figure is 27pp. The COVID years (2020–22) saw inflated grades across the board and are not comparable. But even comparing 2018–19 directly with 2023–24, there has been no closing of the gap.

The Graph: What 3,000 Schools Tell Us

The chart below shows every non-selective secondary school in England for which 2024–25 data are available — around 3,100 schools in total. Each dot represents one school.

- **Horizontal axis:** The percentage of a school's disadvantaged pupils who achieved a good pass (grade 5+ in English and Maths).
- **Vertical axis:** The gap at that school — how far disadvantaged pupils trail their non-disadvantaged classmates.

The colour density shows where most schools cluster. The vertical red dashed line marks 60% — a threshold we use to identify genuinely outstanding performance.

What the chart shows:

The mass of schools clusters in the 10–40% range for disadvantaged pass rates — consistent with the national average of 26%. Most schools also show a gap of 15–30pp.

There is a clear downward trend: schools with higher pass rates for disadvantaged pupils tend to have **smaller gaps**. But the relationship is modest — raising outcomes for disadvantaged pupils does not automatically compress the gap, and some high-performing schools for disadvantaged pupils still have substantial gaps (because their non-disadvantaged pupils also do very well).

The schools to the right of the red dashed line — 52 non-selective schools with 60%+ pass rates for disadvantaged pupils — are the subject of the rest of this briefing.

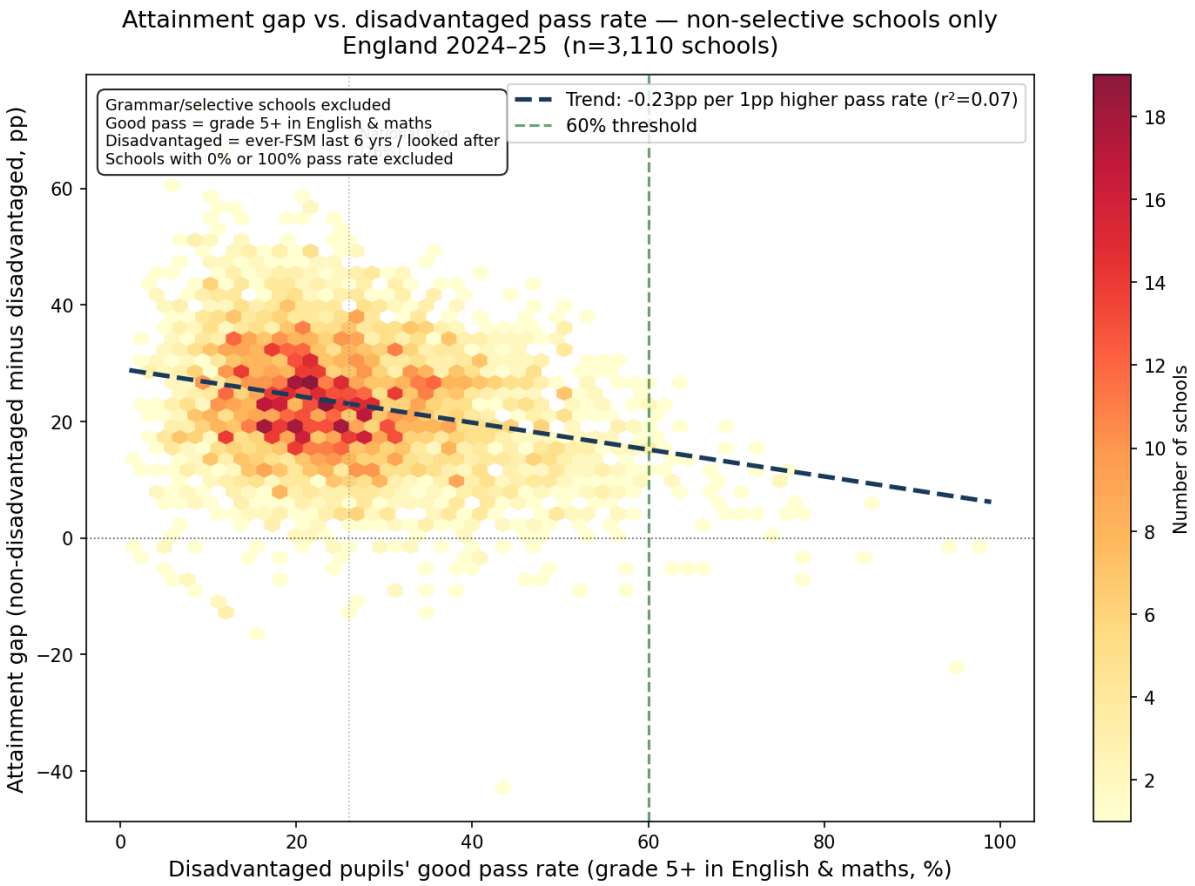

Figure 1: Gap between disadvantaged and non-disadvantaged pupils vs. disadvantaged pass rate, non-selective state secondary schools, 2024–25. Each cell represents the density of schools. Schools with 0% or 100% pass rates are excluded as likely anomalies.

The Map: Where Are the High-Performing Schools?

The map below shows those 52 schools plotted across England.

- **Colour** indicates the school's religious character: faith schools are shown in orange; non-faith in teal.
- **Size** indicates the number of disadvantaged pupils in the cohort — larger circles = more pupils.

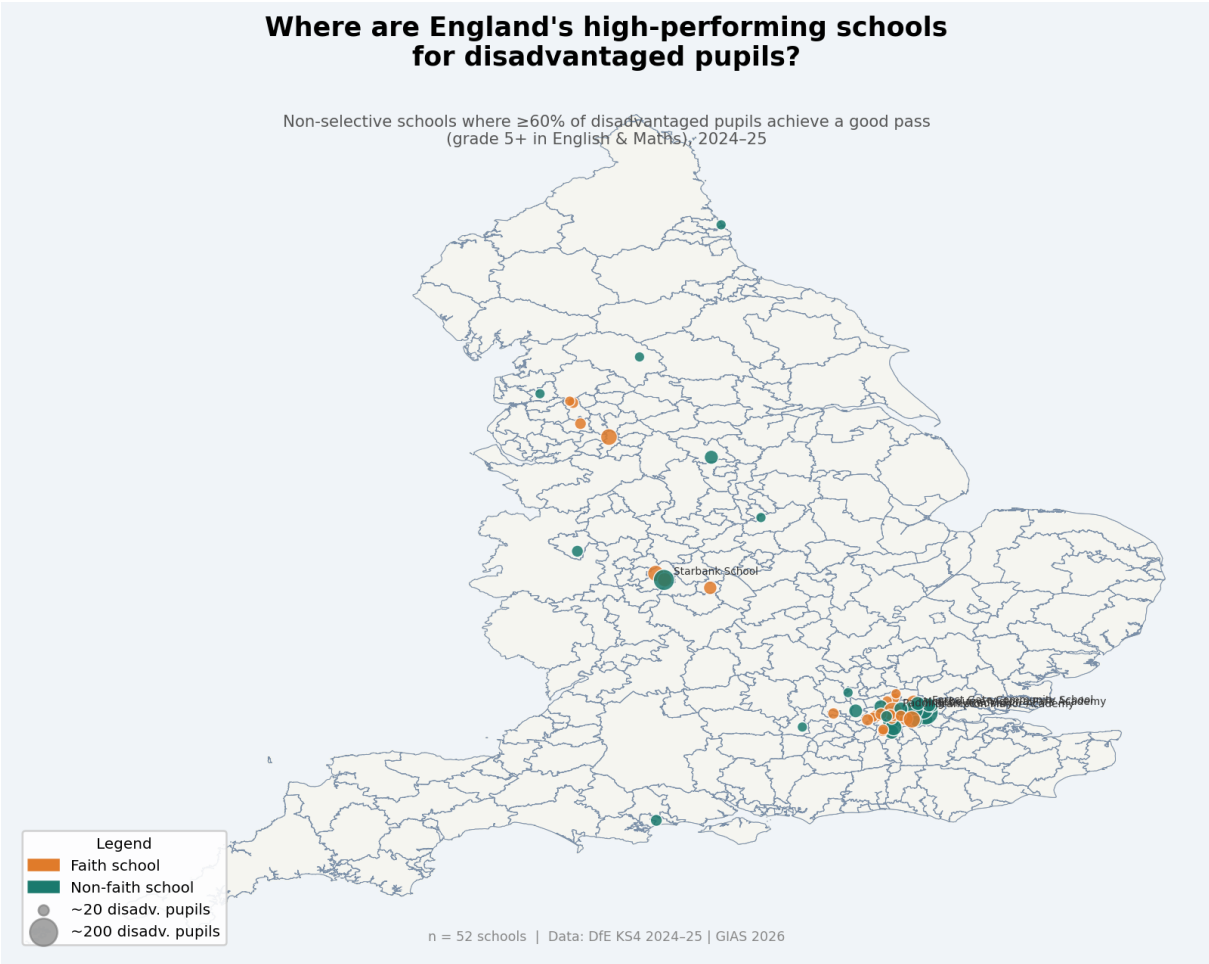

Figure 2: Non-selective state secondary schools achieving 60%+ good pass rate for disadvantaged pupils, 2024–25. Colour = religious character; size = number of disadvantaged pupils.

The geographic concentration is striking. **London dominates.** Around two-thirds of the 52 schools are in the capital. Outside London, there are scattered examples in the North West and Yorkshire, but very few in the Midlands, South West, or East of England.

This is partly a structural story — London has more free schools, more academy chains with strong disadvantage track records, and a higher density of faith schools serving diverse urban communities. But it also raises a direct question for NIoT: **where is the equivalent provision in the rest of the country?**

Who Are These Schools?

Key facts about the 52 schools

- **25 are faith schools** (48%) — compared with around 30% of state secondary schools nationally. Catholic schools and Church of England schools are both represented, alongside schools with Islamic character.
- **33 are in London** (63%) — particularly Inner and East London.
- **Many belong to strong academy chains**: Star Academies, Ark Schools, Harris Federation, and Mossbourne Community Academy Trust are all represented. **8 of the 52 are in Star Academies alone.**
- **Most are relatively large** — median roll of around 800–1,000 pupils, with substantial disadvantaged cohorts. These are not small schools where a handful of pupils can move the needle.

What these schools have in common

Several features recur across the 52 schools, though none is universal:

1. Strong chain membership. The majority belong to multi-academy trusts with an explicit and long-standing commitment to disadvantage. Star Academies, Ark, and Harris all have documented approaches to closing the gap — structured curricula, high-dosage tutoring, extended school days, and rigorous professional development for staff. This is not accidental excellence; it is systematically built in.

2. London location and the "London Effect". The concentration in London reflects two decades of sustained improvement effort in the capital. The London Challenge (2003–2011) transformed some of the country's worst-performing schools. Many of today's high-performing chains grew out of that period. The effects persist — but they also demonstrate that context matters. London schools operate in a different labour market, funding environment, and policy ecosystem.

3. Faith character. Catholic and Islamic schools appear disproportionately in this group. Research suggests this may relate to school ethos, parental engagement, and the motivation structures that religious schools can sustain. This finding is not straightforward to transfer — but it points to the value of strong, shared school culture.

4. Size and stability. These are mostly established schools with experienced leadership. None appears to be a recent turnaround case — the evidence suggests sustained, consistent performance over multiple years rather than a one-year spike.

Implications for the National Institute of Teaching

The Pupil Premium good pass gap is one of the most politically and professionally salient measures in English education. The government has committed to halving it. NIoT's work — on teacher development, school leadership, and evidence-based practice — sits directly in the frame.

Several observations are relevant:

1. The gap is structural, not just instructional. The schools closing the gap are not simply those with better lessons. They combine strong curriculum design, coherent professional development, effective use of Pupil Premium funding, and sustained senior leadership commitment. NIoT's teacher development offer must be embedded in this broader ecology, not treated as a stand-alone intervention.

2. The regional distribution is a challenge. Two-thirds of high-performing schools are in London. NIoT's national footprint — and its mission to reach teachers in areas of greatest need — points directly toward the areas where equivalent schools are absent: the East Midlands, South West, and coastal towns. A targeting question follows: should NIoT prioritise placements and partnerships in these underserved regions?

3. The chain effect is real and transferable. Star Academies and Ark have demonstrated that sustained improvement for disadvantaged pupils is achievable at scale. Understanding how these chains develop their teachers — and how NIoT can learn from and work with them — is a live strategic question.

4. The 60% threshold is not a ceiling. The national average is 26%. That 52 non-selective schools have cleared 60% — double the national rate — shows that the structural barriers are not insuperable. It also implies that the Schools White Paper target (roughly 40%) is achievable in principle, but will require more than incremental improvement in most of the country.

Technical Notes

Data: DfE Key Stage 4 Performance tables, 2024–25 (provisional). School-level breakdown by disadvantage status. "Good pass" = `engmath_95_percent` (grade 5+ in both English Language and Mathematics GCSE). Disadvantaged = ever-FSM in past 6 years + looked after children (pupil premium definition). Non-selective schools identified via GIAS (Get Information About Schools) admissions policy data. n = 3,110 non-selective state-funded secondary schools with non-suppressed disadvantaged data. 2,275 schools suppressed (typically where the disadvantaged cohort is fewer than 6 pupils).

Map boundaries: England local authority boundaries from martinjc/UK-GeoJSON. School coordinates from GIAS Easting/Northing (OSGB36), converted to WGS84.

COVID caveat: 2019–20 to 2021–22 results (centre- and teacher-assessed grades) are not comparable with exam years and are excluded from trend analysis.

Analysis: Python (pandas, matplotlib, pyproj). Data collected April 2026.

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